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BANERJEE AT ONE OF HER NUMEROUS PROTESTS IN KOLKATA

Drama QUEEN

A brief history of her antics

■ 1974/75: As a youth Congress worker Mamata Banerjee danced on the bonnet of a car carrying veteran leader Jayaprakash Narayan in Kolkata

■ 1996: Squatted in the well of the Lok Sabha to protest against petroleum price hike; clasped Samajwadi MP Amar Singh's collar in Parliament

■ 1997: Flung a shawl at Ram Vilas Paswan, Union railways minister, in the Lok Sabha for supposedly ignoring West Bengal's needs

■ 1998: Made a noose with her shawl on stage and threatened to hang herself over the Congress' secret deals with the Left

■ 2006: Hurling her resignation letter at deputy speaker C. S. Atwal in the Lok Sabha

tured into a visions person," claims Amit Mitra, secretary general of the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry. "Her rail budget reveals calibrated commercial engagement and highly advanced ideas."

"Today, if there's a Left then it's Mamata," declares Debabrata Bandyopadhyay, the man who allegedly drafted her Singur and Nandigram blueprint. The former land reforms commissioner of Bengal, once devoted to the Left's land policy, now lists out Didi's main points of concern: redefining 'public purpose' to suit private use of land; ignoring state rules for acquiring land; not considering those who depend on land directly for livelihood for compensation; ignoring the rights of tribals against displacement and a grievance redressal mechanism. "Why do you need forcible acquisition for industrialisation? Entrepreneurs can do it on their own," Bandyopadhyay says. "Every major amendment is for progress. This Bill is worse than the colonial law."

But is it really her new vision and

persona or the changing political context? "She has got her political arithmetic right this time around," holds sociologist Anjan Ghosh of Kolkata. As the hegemonic, corporatised image of the Left made it unpopular, Didi put up an alternative front. Going by past record, she has little to offer in terms of a coherent political ideology. And, hence, no hesitation in radically widening her motley support base—the urban middle class, rural poor, Muslims, intellectuals, disenchanted Left and Maoist think tanks. "She is a shrewd politician, who has decided to move from street drama mode to cool, calculated politics."

It is easy to win, but not that easy to handle victory. First up, Didi goes "me alone". "She doesn't have a party. She is the party," says writer and activist, Jaya Mitra. Nobody else in her party equals her in profile as a cabinet minister and even her closest lieutenants are "punished" for questioning her. "Didi doesn't like it if you don't listen to her"—that's the first primer as a Trinamool worker.

Also, in her last two avatars as a minister, she had made far too many

demands for Bengal. Rajiv Gandhi got tired; P.V. Narasimha Rao was more caustic, causing her to declare independence from Congress. She chose the BJP, but the bond proved weak. She rediscovered the Congress. In a political career spanning 25 years, she has often been left holding nothing. This time around, too, she is turning out to be a leader who has Bengal firmly on her radar. Her stints as railway minister have always seen blatant attempts to squeeze in projects for the state.

Meantime Kolkata streets, sporting thousands of her billboards and posters for the first time in 32 years of Left rule, are telling her new story. So has Didi finally arrived? She had found her niche long back as a "Didi" and also her own dramatic style and rhetoric. Now, finally, she has found her cause—in land. In the recent debacle over Bengal's industrial fate versus land rights, she has won the battle against the Red brigade and the Tatas. But on a national canvas, will her obsession with land work or turn out to be her nemesis? Crystal ball gazers are hard at work.